A Different Kind of Rich



The global luxury industry is in a bit of a spot. Sales have dipped from their 2023 peak, and steep price increases are testing even wealthy buyers' willingness to pay. India, however, is somewhat of a different story. Its wealthy are spending more on travel, hospitality, wellness, and experiences that go beyond flaunting expensive purchases like handbags and supercars.

This shift is at the heart of our Luxury Special Issue. As *Smita Tripathi* writes, India's experiential luxury market is expanding by around 20% annually, with demand spreading beyond the metros. From Antarctic expeditions and wilderness retreats to immersive dining and wellness, the well-heeled Indian is seeking privacy, personal attention, and something worth remembering. Brands and badges still matter, but that is only part of the story.

It would, however, be wrong to assume India is simply following China's path. As *Pradip K. Saha* writes, the ranks of wealthy buyers are swelling across the country, but that does not mean a rush for international labels at any price. Indians are famously hard-nosed when it comes to value. After all, this is a country where even a supercar buyer is said to ask how many kilometres it gives per litre. That instinct prevails even in those with bulge bracket bank balances. And as entrepreneurs and business owners beyond the metros join the ranks of Indian luxury buyers, brands will have to work harder to convince them that what they offer is lasting prestige, and not just a fleeting moment for an Instagram reel.

Last year, our special issue explored India's luxury hotel boom. This year, we look at a related trend—the growth of luxury wildlife tourism. Once centred largely on tiger reserves, it now extends to Jawai's leopard country, the lions of Gir, Assam's rhinos, and Ladakh's snow leopards. Leading hotel chains and boutique resorts are investing in properties that combine wildlife and wellness. The business model is straightforward: affluent travellers will stay longer and spend more for a curated experience that caters to their high expectations.

If the wilderness is not your idea of indulgence, there is plenty else on offer. A growing appetite for expensive pop-up dining experiences is evident in the nearly $1,000 dinner hosted in Delhi earlier this year by Michelin-starred chef Massimo Bottura. Then there is the coveted table at chef Prateek Sadhu's restaurant in Kasauli. These show how gastronomic luxury is finding an enthusiastic audience among younger professionals, who are willing to spend big on an exceptional meal.

Wellness is another facet of this growing appetite. At a clinic in Kozhikode, Kerala, built with an investment exceeding $100 million, a night costs $1,250 plus taxes.

And for those with even deeper pockets, there is art. As *Sakshi Batra* writes, the record $18-million acquisition of Raja Ravi Varma's *Yashoda and Krishna* this April shows just how much collectors are willing to fork out.

Luxury in India is not just about what money can buy. It is about what money allows you to savour.

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